

she'll decide that boring ol' Mom and Dad turned out to be right: it's better to save than to spend, and having a healthy relationship with money is ultimately way more fun than blowing it on cheap thrills.

Congratulations! You've just given your child a 10-year MBA—and you didn't have to spend thousands of dollars on an advanced degree.

Money Mistake: *You Need Time to Instill Values*

The Fix: *Start a Sunday Family Dinner Tradition*

With all this emphasis on financial literacy, you might think I'm saying money is the only thing with true value. That couldn't be further from the truth. Look at the title of this chapter: Give Your Kids an MBA. Money is just the mortar. The time you spend with your kids is invaluable, worth far more than dollars.

Years ago, my wife and I started a family tradition: no matter what else was going on, we agreed to sit down together at least one night a week for a family dinner. Sunday evening worked best; I was home from work and the kids weren't running out the door to a soccer game or a party. At these Sunday dinners, we'd talk about what had happened during the previous week, sharing news and offering support. It was a time to talk about what was going on in our lives and to truly listen to one another. Linda and I learned a long time ago that the best way to get our kids to open up was if we opened up first. The minute you sit your kids down and say, "Tell us about your week," it's game over. Instead, Linda and I would talk very candidly about our own struggles—the email Linda sent out that no one responded to, the tough decision I had to make at work. Sunday-night dinners were a chance for us to share our own experiences and to invite our kids to share theirs. In our household, those evenings were sacrosanct.

As my kids grew older, they began to ask if they could invite their friends over for Sunday family dinner. The more the merrier, Linda and I felt. We encouraged Savannah and Trevor to bring people, knowing that we'd be able to share our family values in a relaxed